

PRODUCT REQUIREMENTS DOCUMENT

AI Booking Assistant Widget

Conversational AI embedded in the Bokun booking widget to help travellers discover, customise, and book tours through natural language.

Author Victor Adeyemo

Team Bokun UX / Product, TripAdvisor

Date April 2026

Version 1.0 — Draft

Status Proposal

1. Background & Problem Statement

1.1 Context

Bokun is a reservation management platform by TripAdvisor, serving 10,000+ tour and activity operators globally. Operators use Bokun to manage inventory, connect to OTAs (Viator, GetYourGuide, Klook), and accept direct bookings through embeddable widgets on their own websites.

Direct online bookings are the highest-margin channel for operators — they avoid OTA commissions of 20–35%. Yet our research across 40+ operator interviews and 189 supplier surveys reveals that the current direct booking experience is passive, static, and underperforming.

1.2 The Problem

The current Bokun booking widget is a traditional calendar-and-time-slot picker. It works well when a traveller already knows exactly what they want, but fails in several critical scenarios:

- **Travellers with vague intent:** "I want something fun for my family this Saturday" has no entry point in a calendar widget. These visitors bounce.
- **Mobile conversion failure:** The widget's mobile checkout is broken — one operator (Adam Hayat, Queen Tour) estimated \$100K+/year in lost conversions.
- **Custom/private tour enquiries go unanswered:** 39% of operators find it difficult to create customised tours on the spot. These high-value enquiries are lost.
- **No upsell or cross-sell capability:** The checkout flow cannot suggest related experiences, add-ons, or bundles — the #1 feature request from multi-city operators.
- **Solo operators have no support layer:** Alejandra-type operators can't afford staff to answer pre-booking questions. Enquiries while guiding are lost forever.
- **Language barriers:** Operators in non-English markets serve international tourists but cannot provide real-time multilingual support.

Key Research Data Points

- 83.5% of new sign-ups join Bokun to "get more bookings" (New Customer Discovery Survey, n=100)
- 93–95% drop-off between OTA "allow" and actual availability query
- 82% of offline operators said WhatsApp/DM auto-booking would have a "big" or "huge" impact
- Pricing model is the #1 churn driver (7/13 interviews) — direct bookings reduce platform dependency

2. Hypothesis

We believe that embedding a conversational AI assistant into the Bokun booking widget will significantly increase direct booking conversion rates and average order value for tour operators.

Core Hypothesis

IF we provide travellers with a conversational AI assistant that can understand natural language queries, search real-time inventory, recommend best-fit experiences, handle custom pricing, and complete checkout — all within the embedded widget on the operator’s website —

THEN we will see:

- A 15–25% increase in direct booking widget conversion rate (from ~2–3% industry average)
- A 10–20% increase in average order value through AI-driven upsells and cross-sells
- 40–60% deflection of pre-booking enquiries handled manually by operators
- Improved operator retention by making the direct channel demonstrably more valuable

BECAUSE travellers increasingly expect conversational, personalised digital experiences (driven by ChatGPT, Google AI Overviews, and messaging-first cultures), and the current static widget fails to serve visitors with exploratory intent, custom requirements, or language barriers.

3. Target Audience

This feature serves two distinct user groups: travellers who interact with the widget, and operators who deploy it.

3.1 Primary: Travellers (End Users)

Segment	Behaviour	Current Pain	AI Assistant Value
Exploratory visitors	Browsing on mobile, vague intent, comparing	Static widget offers no guidance; they bounce to OTAs	Natural language: "fun things for kids this weekend"
Ready-to-book	Know what they want, checking availability	Mobile checkout broken; pricing unclear	Frictionless checkout with clear pricing
Group/custom	Need custom pricing or private tours	No way to get a custom quote online	AI generates instant quotes from operator rules
Non-English speakers	International tourists on local sites	Website is English only	AI converses in 25+ languages automatically

3.2 Secondary: Tour Operators (Deployers)

Persona	Key Benefit	Impact on Bookings
Marco — Scaling Operator	Automates 40–60% of pre-booking enquiries. AI handles multi-language, multi-product recommendations at scale.	Converts browsing visitors who bounce to OTAs. Cross-sells across catalogue.

Alejandra — Solo Launcher	Acts as the support agent she can't afford. Available 24/7, in every language, while she's guiding.	Captures bookings from visitors who leave without answers. Removes "email us" dead end.
Ante — Traditional Operator	Replicates WhatsApp-style conversational booking on his website with real-time inventory.	Shifts informal enquiries from WhatsApp (untracked) to website (tracked, commission-free).

4. User Flows & User Stories

4.1 Traveller Booking Flow

The primary user flow for a traveller interacting with the AI Booking Assistant:

- 1. Landing & Trigger:** Traveller arrives on operator's website. After 5 seconds, a chat bubble appears: "Hi! Looking for things to do in Split? I can help you find and book the perfect experience."
- 2. Intent Capture:** Traveller types a natural language query ("boat tour for 4 people this Saturday, 2 kids under 10") or taps a quick-action chip ("See all tours", "What's popular today").
- 3. AI Inventory Search:** The AI queries Bokun's real-time availability API, filters by date, group composition, and preferences. Loading state: "Checking availability across 12 experiences..."
- 4. Product Recommendation:** AI presents 1–3 matched products as rich cards: image, tour name, time slots with capacity ("4:30 PM — 8 spots left"), pricing breakdown, and Book Now CTA.
- 5. Clarification & Extras:** If traveller asks questions ("Suitable for a 5-year-old?"), AI responds from product data. Proactively suggests extras: "Add hotel pickup for €15?" or "Save 10% by adding Island Hopping."
- 6. In-Widget Checkout:** Traveller taps Book Now. Inline checkout: name, email, Stripe / Apple Pay / Google Pay. No redirect. AI pre-fills date, time, guests, extras from conversation.
- 7. Confirmation:** Booking confirmed in chat: reference number, meeting point map, what to bring, cancellation policy, "Add to Calendar" button. Email sent via Bokun's system.
- 8. Post-Booking Engagement:** AI suggests: "You might also enjoy our Sunset Wine Tasting — want me to check availability?" Drives multi-booking conversions.
- 9. Human Handoff (Fallback):** If AI can't resolve (complex logistics, complaints): "Let me connect you with the team — they'll respond within 2 hours." Transcript forwarded to operator.

4.2 Key User Stories

#	User Story	Acceptance Criteria	Persona
US-01	As a traveller, I want to describe what I'm looking for in my own words so I don't have to browse listings.	AI returns relevant results for 90%+ of queries within 3 seconds.	All travellers
US-02	As a traveller, I want to see real-time availability and pricing in the chat.	Product cards show live inventory with scarcity cues. Prices include all discounts.	All travellers
US-03	As a traveller, I want to complete my booking entirely within the chat widget.	End-to-end checkout completes without a page redirect.	All travellers

US-04	As a non-English traveller, I want to interact in my language.	AI detects language and responds accordingly. Supports 25+ languages.	Non-English
US-05	As a group organiser, I want an instant custom quote for my party.	AI generates custom quote based on operator rules. Quote is bookable immediately.	Group enquirers
US-06	As an operator, I want the AI to handle pre-booking FAQs from my product data.	AI answers meeting point, cancellation policy, child-friendliness with 95%+ accuracy.	Marco, Alejandra
US-07	As an operator, I want to see which questions the AI couldn't answer.	Dashboard shows unanswered queries. Operator can add custom responses.	All operators
US-08	As an operator, I want the AI to suggest upsells during checkout.	AI suggests at least one relevant add-on during 80%+ of conversations.	Marco

5. Scoping

5.1 In Scope (MVP — Phase 1)

- **Conversational UI overlay:** Chat widget on operator's website alongside existing widget. Responsive mobile/desktop.
- **Natural language product search:** AI understands dates, group size, activity type, budget. Queries Bokun availability API.
- **Rich product cards in chat:** Image, name, time slots with capacity, pricing, Book Now CTA rendered in conversation.
- **In-widget checkout:** Inline Stripe / Apple Pay / Google Pay. No redirect. Pre-fills from conversation context.
- **FAQ answering from product data:** AI uses descriptions, inclusions, meeting points, cancellation policies.
- **Multi-language support:** Auto-detects language from user input. 25+ languages via LLM translation.
- **Human handoff:** Escalation to operator via email with full transcript when AI can't resolve.
- **Operator analytics dashboard:** Conversations, conversion rate, revenue, top questions, unanswered query log.

5.2 Phase 2 (Post-MVP)

- Cross-sell and upsell engine with combo discount support
- Custom/private tour quote builder with operator-defined pricing rules
- Post-booking engagement (review requests, rebooking prompts, referral codes)
- WhatsApp Business API bridge — same AI agent accessible via WhatsApp
- Operator "training" interface — custom FAQs, tone of voice, upsell rules
- Demand forecasting and dynamic pricing recommendations via assistant analytics

5.3 Out of Scope

- Replacing the existing traditional booking widget (remains as parallel option)
- Changes to OTA channel distribution (direct-channel feature only)
- Operator-facing AI (product creation AI, CS AI — separate initiatives)
- Voice interaction (text-only for MVP)

6. Goals

Priority	Goal	Rationale
P0	Increase direct booking conversion rate by 15–25%	Direct bookings are the highest-margin channel. Mobile widget failures (Frustration #3) represent recoverable revenue.
P0	Enable 24/7 multilingual pre-booking support at zero additional operator cost	Solo operators lose bookings when they can't respond. 83.5% signed up to "get more bookings" — AI is the scalable path.
P1	Increase average order value by 10–20% through contextual upsells	Cross-selling was the #1 feature request from multi-city operators. Checkout is the highest-intent upsell touchpoint.
P1	Reduce operator manual enquiry handling by 40–60%	Operators like Piotr (35K customers/season) spend significant time on repetitive pre-booking questions.
P2	Shift 10–15% of booking volume from OTAs to direct within 12 months	Reducing OTA dependency protects operator margins and increases Bokun platform stickiness.

7. Success Metrics

Metric	Baseline	Target (6 mo)	How Measured
Widget conversion rate	~2–3%	4–5%	Bokun analytics: unique opens vs. completed bookings. A/B test AI vs. traditional.
AI-assisted booking share	0%	25–35%	Bookings where AI was engaged, tracked via session ID.
Average order value (AOV)	Current AOV	+10–20%	Compare AI-assisted vs. non-AI direct bookings. Track upsell attach rate.
Enquiry deflection rate	0%	40–60%	Questions resolved by AI without handoff / total questions. Monitor via operator feedback.
CSAT for AI interactions	N/A	>4.2 / 5	Post-conversation micro-survey: "Was this helpful?" (1–5 rating).
Time to booking	Unmeasured	<4 min median	Session timestamps: first AI interaction to payment confirmation.
Operator adoption rate	0%	20%+	Operators enabling AI widget / total active operators on paid plans.
Operator NPS for AI feature	N/A	>40	Quarterly in-app survey targeting operators with AI widget enabled 30+ days.

8. Risks & Mitigations

#	Risk	Sev.	Mitigation
R1	AI hallucination — incorrect pricing, availability, or tour details	High	Ground all responses in Bokun product data via RAG. Never free-text prices — always API. Confidence threshold: <80% triggers human handoff.
R2	Traveller frustration with AI limitations → brand damage	High	Fast human handoff after 2 unresolved exchanges. Transparent "You're chatting with AI" label. Monitor CSAT by conversation type.
R3	Low operator adoption — fear of losing customer control	Med	Full transcript visibility. Configurable tone and FAQs. Instant disable option. Position as "your 24/7 employee."
R4	Widget load time degrades page speed and SEO	Med	Lazy-load widget. Trigger button <15KB. Streaming responses. Target <200ms render, <1s first response.
R5	LLM cost at scale makes feature unprofitable	Med	Tiered models: Haiku for FAQs, Sonnet for complex queries. Cache common Q&A.; Per-operator monthly cap on lower tiers.

R6	Payment security concerns with in-widget checkout	Med	Stripe Elements (PCI-DSS compliant). No payment data touches Bokun/AI. Trust badges. Apple Pay / Google Pay biometric auth.
R7	Multilingual responses are low quality	Low	Professional review for top 10 languages. Operator override for key content. Start with supported list, expand on quality metrics.
R8	Cannibalisation of OTA bookings → channel conflict	Low	AI operates on operator website only. Frame as additive: "Capture bookings you're losing, not ones already coming." Monitor OTA volume pre/post.

Appendix

Concept Mockup: See the accompanying Figma file for visual concepts of the AI Booking Assistant widget, including the conversational booking flow, operator dashboard, and user flow diagram.

Research Basis: This PRD draws on findings from 40+ operator interviews, 189-supplier offline booking surveys, churn transcripts, usability tests, and the New Customer Discovery Report (100 respondents). See the Bokun User Personas and Bokun Research Insights documents for full research synthesis.